



Three games later, Sinner made history as the first Australian Open champion not among the legendary Big Three since 2014 when Stan Wawrinka upset Rafael Nadal.

He also became the first Italian man to capture a Grand Slam singles title since Adriano Panatta won the 1976 French Open and the youngest men's AO champion since Novak Djokovic in 2008.

Lastly, he dealt The King of Hard Courts, his first loss as the No. 1 seed after entering the AO at 47-0.

Tennis aficionados and historians will also remember Sinner as a massive streak breaker thanks to his 6-1, 6-2, 6-7 (6), 6-3 semifinal upset over Djokovic.

If the result was surprising, the score was shocking. Djokovic had to stave off a match point in the

tiebreaker just to extend the match to four sets.

Beating the GOAT at Melbourne — where The Djoker had amassed a perfect 10-0 record in both semifinals and finals — was a testament both to his superb performance and Djokovic's mystifyingly abysmal play.

When Novak committed his 13th unforced error, a backhand approach that landed deep, to lose his serve and fall behind 5-1, the crowd murmured in disbelief. A game later, *ESPN* analyst and 1980s superstar John McEnroe said, "I'd be truly amazed if Novak continued to play at that level."

At 2-all in the third set, McEnroe borrowed a catchphrase from the 1970s TV show *What's My Line* where contestants tried to figure out who

the masked celebrity was.

Mac quipped, "Will the real Novak Djokovic please stand up?," adding "soon." This Djokovic wasn't an impersonator at least during the tiebreaker, his forte.

In retrospect, the much-improved Sinner should have been considered a slight favourite given his terrific record against elite opponents in the past four months: 2-1 against Djokovic, 1-0 against Carlos Alcaraz, and 3-0 against Medvedev.

During the press conference, Djokovic graciously told the crowd, "I want to congratulate Sinner for playing a great match. He outplayed me completely today."

Then he admitted, "I was shocked by my level — in a bad way. This was one of the worst grand Slam matches I have ever played."